CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The United States Colored Troops

Nearly 180,000 Black men put on the Union blue and fought for a freedom that was still only a promise. 1863–1865.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Nearly 180,000 Black men put on the Union blue and fought for a freedom that was still only a promise. 1863–1865.

What does it mean to fight for a country that has not yet decided whether you are a citizen?

The Army Opens Its Ranks

1863

The Emancipation Proclamation did more than free the enslaved in rebel territory — it opened the Union army to Black soldiers. In May 1863 the War Department created the Bureau of Colored Troops to organize them into regiments: the United States Colored Troops, or USCT.

Recruiters fanned out across the North and the occupied South. Posters like the one below called Black men to enlist — to fight, as the slogan put it, for their own people and their own freedom.

"Come and Join Us Brothers" — recruiting chromolithograph, Supervisory Committee for Recruiting Colored Regiments, Philadelphia, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

"Come and Join Us Brothers"

THE CALL TO ENLIST

A recruiting poster aimed at Black men. Notice the detail: a young drummer boy, a determined line of soldiers, the United States flag. The message is that these men belong in this army, and in this nation.

"Come and Join Us Brothers" — recruiting chromolithograph, Supervisory Committee for Recruiting Colored Regiments, Philadelphia, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

≈180,000

BY THE NUMBERS

By the end of the war, roughly 180,000 Black men had served in the USCT — about 10% of the entire Union army — in some 175 regiments. Another 19,000 served in the Navy.

They fought in 39 major battles and hundreds of smaller actions. Roughly 40,000 died — the great majority, as in the whole war, from disease. Sixteen USCT soldiers and seven sailors earned the Medal of Honor.

"Come and Join Us Brothers" — recruiting broadside for the U.S. Colored Troops, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Same Risk, Not the Same Pay

UNEQUAL, AND THEY KNEW IT

Black soldiers faced dangers white soldiers did not. If captured, they risked being killed or sold into slavery rather than taken prisoner — as happened at the Fort Pillow massacre in 1864, where surrendering Black troops were slaughtered.

And for most of the war they were paid less: $10 a month, minus a clothing fee, versus $13 for white soldiers. In protest, the men of the 54th Massachusetts refused all pay for over a year until Congress finally granted equal pay in 1864.

"Come and Join Us Brothers" — recruiting chromolithograph, Supervisory Committee for Recruiting Colored Regiments, Philadelphia, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

FREDERICK DOUGLASS

Once let the black man get upon his person the brass letters, U.S. … and there is no power on earth … which can deny that he has earned the right to citizenship.

Soldiers Into Citizens

WHY IT MATTERS

The service of the USCT was an argument made in blood: that men willing to fight and die for the United States had earned a place in it. That argument helped drive the 13th, 14th, and 15th Amendments — ending slavery, granting citizenship, and protecting the vote.

The promise would be broken again and again in the decades that followed. But the 180,000 had changed the question forever. After the USCT, no one could honestly say that Black Americans had not fought for their own freedom.

"Come and Join Us Brothers" — recruiting chromolithograph, Supervisory Committee for Recruiting Colored Regiments, Philadelphia, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

Make the Numbers Speak

YOUR TURN

You'll work with the statistics of Black service in the Union army and practice turning raw numbers into a historical argument about citizenship and sacrifice.